from the enormous treasure chest of Mughal gems plundered by the Persian marauder Nadir Shah from the Red Fort in Delhi sixty years earlier; these Ahmad Shah had seized within an hour of Nadir Shah's assassination.[b]

Putting this wealth at the service of his cavalry, Ahmad Shah hardly ever lost a battle, but he was ultimately defeated by a foe more intractable than any army. He had had his face eaten away by what the Afghan sources call a 'gangrenous ulcer', possibly leprosy or some form of cancer. At the height of his power, when after eight successive raids on the plains of north India he finally crushed the massed cavalry of the Marathas at the Battle of Panipat in 1761, Ahmad Shah's disease had already consumed his nose, and a diamond-studded substitute was attached in its place. As his army grew to a horde of 120,000 and his Empire expanded, so did the tumour, ravaging his brain, spreading to his chest and throat, and incapacitating his limbs.[14] He sought healing in Sufi shrines, but none of this brought him the cure he craved. In 1772, having despaired of recovery, he took to his bed and, as one Afghan writer put it, 'the leaves and fruit of his date palm fell to the ground, and he returned whence he had come'.[15] The great tragedy of his new Durrani Empire was that its founder died before he could fix the boundaries of his country, build a working administration or properly consolidate his new conquests.

Ahmad Shah's diminutive son, Timur Shah, successfully maintained the heartlands of the Empire his father had bequeathed to him. He moved the capital from Kandahar to Kabul, to keep it out of the turbulent Pashtun heartlands, and looked to the Qizilbash – Shia colonists who first came to Afghanistan from Persia with the armies of Nadir Shah – for his royal guard. Like the Qizilbash, his own Sadozai dynasty were Persian-speaking and culturally Persianised and Timur Shah looked to his Timurid predecessors – 'the Oriental Medici' as Robert Byron dubbed them – for his cultural models. He prided himself on being a man of taste, and revived the formal gardens of the Bala Hisar fort in Kabul first constructed by Shah Jahan's Governor of Kabul, Ali Mardan Khan. In this endeavour, he was inspired by the stories of his senior wife, a Mughal princess who had grown up in the Delhi Red Fort with its courtyards of fountains and shade-giving fruit trees.

Like his Mughal in-laws, he had a talent for dazzling display. 'He modelled his government on that of the great rulers,' records a later court history, the *Siraj ul-Tawarikh*. 'He wore a diamond-studded brooch on his